

A Liberating Learning Infrastructure

Last month we looked at FOSS applications for beginners and students. In this article, we will look at FOSS-in-the-large as applied to a learning environment.

This article is a broad overview of the technology solutions available for learning and does not prejudge any solution as automatically fitting a particular requirement. The data gathering and decision making is left entirely to the reader. If this and the previous article can spur you to explore that part of the FOSS ecosystem that caters to education, they would have served their purpose.

School infrastructure

A common or default approach for a school

computer lab is a network of PCs exclusively running a proprietary OS with some shared directories that host the learning resources. Each student gets a full-fledged PC as a workstation. What could be easier? There is always an obliging hardware vendor around the corner and those helpful education 'discounts' on proprietary software are so tempting.

This approach is wasteful, both in terms of money and energy (aren't we teaching children about carbon footprints in our environmental education classes?). The software is probably hosted individually on each machine and maintaining it is a chore, not to speak of the recurring licence and upgrade costs.

Contrast this with a FOSS approach, which has a high capacity server for multiple student

